

Credit can be essential to the functioning of many lower-income families, but these same families, lumped together by racist redlining, have a harder time getting approved for credit and a harder time elevating their credit scores enough to get credit cards with which to do the tricks Brian Kelly pulls off. We have to acknowledge this before we begin our journey building credit from scratch.

HOW TO START BUILDING CREDIT FROM SCRATCH

If you want to apply for your first credit card to start building credit, here are some helpful hints:

FIND A COSIGNER. To get a credit card without a credit score, you might need a cosigner—someone with good credit who will sign off on your credit card on your behalf and assume responsibility for your debts if you can't pay them off. Don't not pay them off, or you'll be screwing over someone else too.

GET EMPLOYED. Having a job can make you seem trustworthy enough to get approved for a credit card because it's assumed you'll be able to pay it back every month. (You can get one without a job or if you're a freelancer like I was, but the company or bank will ask for your income so have that information ready.) If you have a solid income, you can be approved without any previous credit. But you can't use your parents' or cosigner's income for this one.

KNOW THYSELF. Figure out what kind of person you are. And I don't just mean are you a Gemini obsessed with true crime documentaries? It's more like: Are you a student? Because there are cards with specific student rewards. (But some of these cards have very high interest rates and fees because who better to scam than students, right?) Do you love to travel? Then you need a travel rewards card. Do you just love cold-hard cash? Cash back, babyyyy. Look at what you actually spend on and where a credit card would help you. (And my fellow Geminis, have